Yellow Bird and Say Yes

By Andrea Gibson

Say Yes (Pg 86-89)

When two violins are placed in a room
if a chord on one violin is struck
the other violin will sound the note.
If this is your definition of hope,
this is for you
For the ones who know how powerful we are,
who know we can sound the music in the people around us
simply by playing our own strings.
For the ones who sing life into broken wings,
open their chests and offer their breath
as wind on a still day when nothing seems to be moving
spare those intent on proving god is dead.
For you when your fingers are red
from clutching your heart so it will beat faster.
For the time you mastered the art
of giving yourself for the sake of someone else.

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For the ones who have felt what it is to crush the lies
and lift truth so high the steeples bow to the sky

This is for you

INTRODUCTION

Author Philip Pullman once said, "Children need art and stories and poems and music as much as they need love and food and fresh air and play. Children in every part of the world are starved for something that nourishes their souls in a way that nothing else ever could. Art, Music, Poetry . . . they not only reflect a nation's identity; they create it. Paint your picture, sing your song, write your story and by doing so create a world you'll be proud to pass on to the children.

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Why is art the first class to be dropped
by any public school?
Why are music rooms empty in junior highs
from New York City to Nashville, Tennessee?
Like the war is worth funding but music isn't?

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Our culture is a prison.
And the only one with the key is little Emi Jones,
covering every inch of her standardized test
with the best number 2 pencil version of
a starry night anyone has ever seen
and yes, there is a humming bird in her chest.
Its wings are beating 80 times a second.
See … Doctor King did not write a speech
called ***I Have a Dream*** - he wrote a poem
called ***I Have a Dream***.

I don't know if God will have a purple heart,
but I know we have a bow we could pull above the strings
of a combat boot and make it sing
like the eyes of a 7-year-old boy
staring down the barrel of Apartheid's loaded guns;
Screaming for the right to write stories;
to sing songs in his Mother's tongue.

Point me in the direction of glory
I will run towards a tiny hand in the most wounded

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corner of Palestine,
dipping a brush into a can of yellow paint
to paint a feather on a wing on a wall that is so tall,
only yellow birds can escape.
And when they do, they carry
the hearts of little girls on their backs.
and when their wings flap, they make the sound of
anthems being replaced with sky.
And I swear, I could see their shadows
pass across your glowing face
the night you said you have never given birth to a child
but you tear every single time you write a poem.

We are growing our future with every borrowed pen
I pray tonight we could write a rain that would fall
like the tears at Folsom State Prison
the day Johnny Cash smashed his guitar over apathy's
head.
The way Frida Kahlo* - in the prison of her own body -
had whole years where she could paint nothing but red
but she painted . . .

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To the bars in the locked cells of her pores.
The same when saxophones in New Orleans
played music underwater,**
knowing some of those notes would rise up to the air
carrying people and hope to shore.

I don't believe in the godliness of steeples,
but I believe in the stained glass
and every key on every organ that is desperate for light,
'cause we are desperate for life -
for the sight of a captivated audience
refusing to be held captive in the thought
that they can only listen and watch.

Picasso said he would paint with his own wet tongue
on the dusty floor of a jail cell if he had to.
We have to create;
it is the only thing louder than destruction;
it is the only chance the bars are gonna break.
Our hands full of color
reaching towards the sky - a brush stroke in the dark --

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It is not too late ,
That starry night - it is not yet dry.

***Find our more about artist Frida Kahlo here**
https://www.fridakahlo.org/

****Reference is to Hurricane Katrina (2005) – Find our more her**
https://www.history.com/topics/natural-disasters-and-environment/hurricane-katrina

Say Yes (Pg 86-89)

[So, you see . . .] This is for the man who showed me
the hardest thing about having nothing
is having nothing to give,
who said the only reason to live is to give ourselves away.
So this is for the day we'll quit or jobs
and work for something real.
We'll feel for sunshine in the shadows,
look for sunrays in the shade.
This is for the people who rattle the cage that slave
wage built,
and for the ones who didn't know the filth until tonight

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but right now are beginning songs that sound something like
people turning their porch lights on
and calling the homeless back home

This is for all the s*** we own,
and for the day we'll learn how much we have
when we learn to give that s*** away.
This is for doubt becoming faith
for falling from grace and climbing back up.
For trading our silver platters for something that matters,
like the gold that shines from our hands
when we hold each other.

This is for your grandmother,
who walked a thousand miles on broken glass
to find that single patch of grass to plant a family tree
where the fruit would grow to laugh.
For the ones who know the math of war
has always been subtraction
so they live like an action of addition.

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For you when you give like every star is wishing on you,
and for the people still wishing on stars
this is for you too.

This is for the times you went through hell
so someone else wouldn't have to.
For the time you taught a 14-year-old girl
she was powerful.
For the time you taught a 14-year-old boy
he was beautiful.
For the radical anarchist asking a republican to dance,
'cause what's the chance of anyone moving from right to left
if the only moves they see are NBC and CBS.
This is for the no becoming yes,
for fear becoming trust,
for saying ***I love you*** to people who will never say it to us.

For scraping away the rust and remembering how to shine.
For the dime you gave away when you didn't have a

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penny,
For the many beautiful things we do,
For every song we've ever sung,
For refusing to believe in miracles
because miracles are the impossible coming true
and everything is possible.

This is for the possibility that guides us
and for the possibilities still waiting to sing
and spread their wings inside us,
'cause tonight Saturn is on his knees
proposing with all of his ten thousand rings
that whatever song we've been singing we sing even more.
The world needs us right now more than it ever has before.
Pull all your strings.
Play every chord.
If you're writing letters to the prisoners
start tearing down the bars.

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If you're handing out flashlights in the dark
start handing out stars.

Never go a second hushing the percussion of your heart.
Play loud.
Play like you know the clouds
have left too many people cold and broken
and you're their last chance for sun.
Play like there's no time for hoping brighter days will come.
Play like the apocalypse is only 4…3…2… but you
have a drum in your chest that could save us.

You have a song like a breath that could raise us
like the sunrise into a dark sky that cries to be blue.
Play like you know we won't survive if you don't
but we will if you do.
Play like Saturn is on his knees
proposing with all of his ten thousand rings
that we give every single breath.
This is for saying, ***YES.***
This is for saying, ***YES.***

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SOURCE INFORMATION – Say Yes

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